

Has Globalisation Improved Well-being in Southeast Asia? Evidence from an Anthropological Perspective

Ansuman Jaiswal

James Cook University, Singapore

1. Introduction

It has been widely argued in policy and mainstream development circles that **globalisation** over the past four decades has improved the well-being of the majority of people in the **Global South**. Supporters of this view point to rising national incomes, expanded trade, and some reductions in extreme poverty as proof that closer integration into global markets has brought broad benefits. In **Southeast Asia**, rapid industrialisation, export-oriented growth, and the expansion of **agro-industrial** commodities such as oil palm are often presented as clear regional success stories. Yet these claims rely heavily on broad statistical indicators and on the assumption that expanding markets naturally leads to better human welfare.

From an anthropological point of view, this assumption is **problematic**. Well-being is not simply a material condition that can be measured by income or growth figures alone. It is experienced through everyday social relations, local ideas about freedom and security, the way labour and care work are organised, and the unequal distribution of power. Globalisation itself should not be seen as a natural economic force. Instead, it is a specific historical project of neoliberal market expansion, supported and shaped by a powerful development discourse that presents the Global South as lacking and in need of external modernisation (Escobar 1995; Harvey 2005). Technical measures of progress often work as an “**anti-politics machine**,” turning questions about who gains and who loses into purely technical issues (Ferguson 1994).

This essay therefore examines the claim that Globalisation has improved majority well-being in Southeast Asia by giving priority to ethnographic and critical anthropological evidence rather than aggregate indicators. It argues that while market integration has created new sources of cash income and some opportunities for certain groups, these gains have come with intensified structural and everyday inequality, the weakening of non-market forms of social security, and changes in social relations that many people experience as mixed or actively harmful. Drawing on ideas about development discourse, neoliberalism, social reproduction, and lived experience, the essay suggests that any serious assessment of well-being must start from local categories and power relations, rather than from the developmentalist story of inevitable progress.

The discussion is organised in four main stages. **First**, the theoretical framework is set out using key anthropological concepts. **Second**, the transformation of social life under neoliberal globalisation in Southeast Asia is examined. **Third**, inequality is analysed as a lived and cultural experience. **Finally**, a critical synthesis evaluates the dominant claim in light of the ethnographic and theoretical evidence.

2. Anthropological Concepts And Theoretical Framework

An anthropological analysis of globalisation and well-being needs concepts that can highlight power, discourse, and everyday social relations, rather than treating market integration as a neutral or purely technical process. Central to this approach is **Escobar's (1995)** understanding of **development as a discourse**. **Escobar** describes it as a historically specific system of knowledge and institutional practices that emerged after **1945** and constructed the “**Third World**” as deficient, underdeveloped, and in need of Western-defined modernisation. This discourse does not simply describe existing conditions; it actively produces the Global South as an object of intervention and shapes what counts as progress, poverty, and improvement. From this perspective, globalisation appears less like a sudden break and more like a continuation and intensification of developmentalist logic under new institutional forms.

Closely related is **Ferguson's (1994)** concept of the **anti-politics machine**. Based on his study of rural development projects in **Lesotho**, **Ferguson** shows that development interventions often fail to reduce poverty in the ways they claim, while still expanding bureaucratic power and depoliticising the problems they address. Poverty and inequality are turned into technical problems of infrastructure, knowledge, markets, or “capacity” that experts can supposedly manage. The same process can be seen in contemporary globalisation through measures such as **GDP** growth, trade volumes, and composite globalisation indices. These indicators turn questions of distribution, power, and history into technical measures of progress, making the political side of economic change largely invisible.

Harvey's (2005) account of neoliberalism provides the political-economic content of recent globalisation. Neoliberalism is a set of ideas and practices that claim human well-being is best achieved by freeing individual entrepreneurial activity within a system of strong private property rights, free markets, and free trade. The **state's role is limited to creating and protecting this framework**. The process of neoliberalisation has involved widespread “creative destruction” of earlier institutions, social relations, welfare systems, and ways of life. Market exchange is raised to the level of an ethic that is supposed to guide all human action. In Southeast Asia, this approach has supported structural adjustment, privatisation, export-oriented industrialisation, and the rapid growth of agro-industrial commodities.

Earlier dependency theory remains useful for understanding the longer history of these processes. **Frank (1966)** argued that underdevelopment is not an original state but is actively produced when peripheral regions are drawn into the capitalist world system through **metropolis-satellite** relations of extraction. The idea of the “**development of underdevelopment**” challenges stories that present rising inequality as only a temporary stage on the way to maturity.

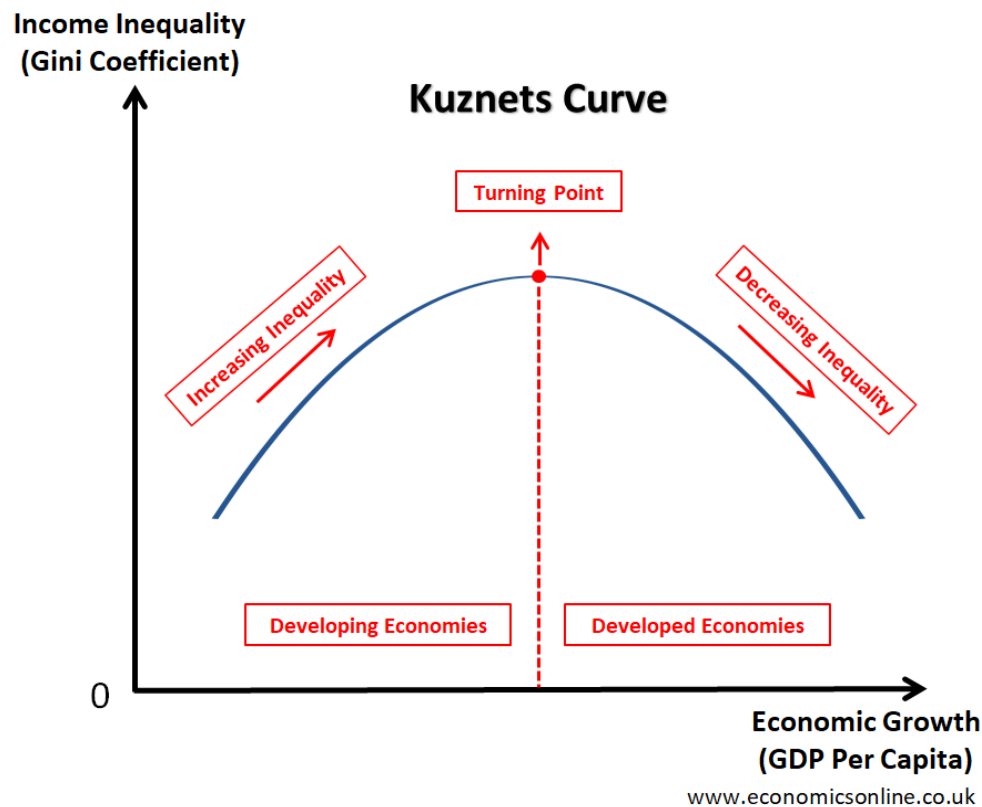


Figure 1. The Kuznets Curve (idealised representation of the relationship between economic growth and inequality).

One such story is the **Kuznets Curve (Kuznets 1955)**. It suggests that inequality first rises and then falls during industrialisation, creating an **inverted-U pattern**. In policy discussions, this idea is often used to present current inequality under globalisation as a necessary and temporary cost of progress. From an anthropological perspective, the claim is weak: it treats inequality as a technical stage rather than a result of power relations, and it has not held up well in much of the Global South under neoliberal conditions.

More recent critical work has taken these ideas into the cultural politics of empowerment. **Hickel (2014)** examines the “**girl effect**” discourse, which presents investment in young women's skills and their participation in the labour market as the main route to growth and poverty reduction. This approach draws on liberal ideas of individual freedom while shifting the responsibility for structural

poverty onto local forms of kinship and personhood. In practice, it often places women in new and precarious positions as workers and debtors.

Finally, ethnographic attention to social reproduction and lived experience is essential. **Tammisto (2019)** shows how people living on and around an oil palm plantation distinguish the “**village**” from the “**plantation**” as two different sets of relations and value regimes. Village-based social reproduction, the work of sustaining life and social relations outside the wage, frequently supports capitalist enterprises while remaining the main focus of workers' lives. Places carry different historical meanings, and the movement of people between them reveals the unequal and often uneasy connection between market and non-market spheres.

Together, these concepts offer a framework for examining globalisation not through broad claims of improvement, but through the ways power, discourse, and social relations reshape everyday life and well-being in Southeast Asia.

3. Globalisation And The Transformation Of Social Life In Southeast Asia

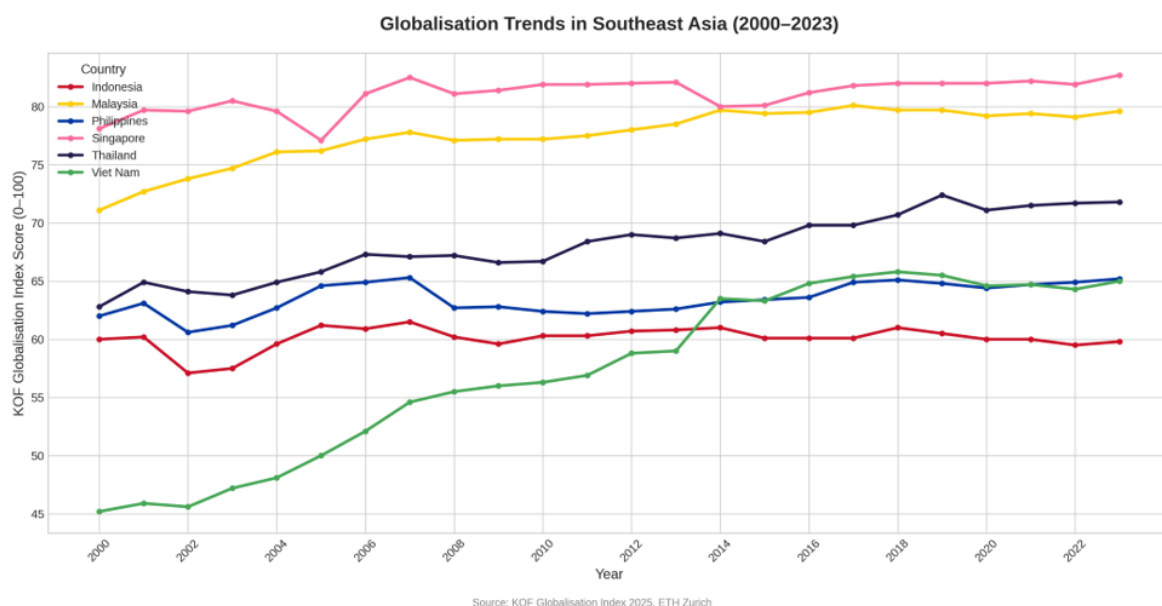


Figure 2. Globalisation trends in selected Southeast Asian countries, 2000–2023 (KOF Globalisation Index).

Source: KOF Swiss Economic Institute.

Official measures show a clear picture of deepening globalisation across Southeast Asia. The **KOF** Globalisation Index indicates a steady rise in scores for most countries in the region between 2000 and 2023, with Singapore and Malaysia staying near the top and Vietnam showing particularly rapid growth (see Figure 2). These figures are regularly presented as evidence that the region has

successfully joined the global economy. From an anthropological point of view, however, the numbers tell us very little about how this integration is actually experienced in everyday life. They record the growth of trade, capital flows, and institutional links, but they say almost nothing about changes in social relations, labour, or the meanings people give to security and freedom.

What these rising scores reflect on the ground is the strengthening of neoliberal market relations of the kind described by **Harvey (2005)**. Across Indonesia, Malaysia, Thailand, Vietnam, and the Philippines, governments and companies have pushed export-oriented industrialisation, special economic zones, and **large-scale agro-industrial expansion**, especially in oil palm. These processes have involved what **Harvey** calls creative destruction in order to open up new spaces for capital. Villages and smallholder landscapes have been partly or fully drawn into global commodity chains. Work has increasingly been organised according to the rules of the plantation, the factory, and the service sector, rather than according to the rhythms of households and communities.

Ethnographic work makes these transformations tangible. Although **Tammisto's (2019)** study is set in **Papua New Guinea**, the social dynamics it records are closely parallel to those found in many Southeast Asia oil-palm and plantation frontiers. **Workers link the village with a sense of autonomy - "life in the village is free" - while the plantation represents controlled, time-disciplined labour** and the need for cash. Importantly, most workers mainly so they can send money home and support village life. In this way, non-market forms of social reproduction continue to support capitalist enterprises. The plantation does not simply replace the village; instead, the two become unequal partners in a tense relationship.

Similar patterns appear across much of rural and **peri-urban Southeast Asia**. Young people, especially women, are drawn into factory work, service jobs, or contract farming under the banner of empowerment and opportunity (**Hickel 2014**). Cash incomes rise for some households, and new forms of mobility and consumption become possible. At the same time, the costs of social reproduction - childcare, food provision, care of the elderly, maintenance of community obligations are frequently pushed back onto families and villages, now with fewer resources and greater precarity. What development discourse presents as modernisation and inclusion is experienced by many people as a shift of responsibility and risk onto themselves.

The official narrative of successful globalisation therefore rests on a selective view. Rising **KOF** scores and periods of strong **GDP** growth show the expansion of market relations, but they do not show the loss of earlier security, the tightening of labour discipline, or the ambiguous moral evaluations people make of these changes. An anthropological approach insists that the transformation of social life cannot be understood from aggregate figures alone. It has to be followed through the concrete ways people move between places, reorganise care and work, and judge whether the new arrangements leave them more or less able to live lives they value.

4. Inequality As Lived And Cultural Experience

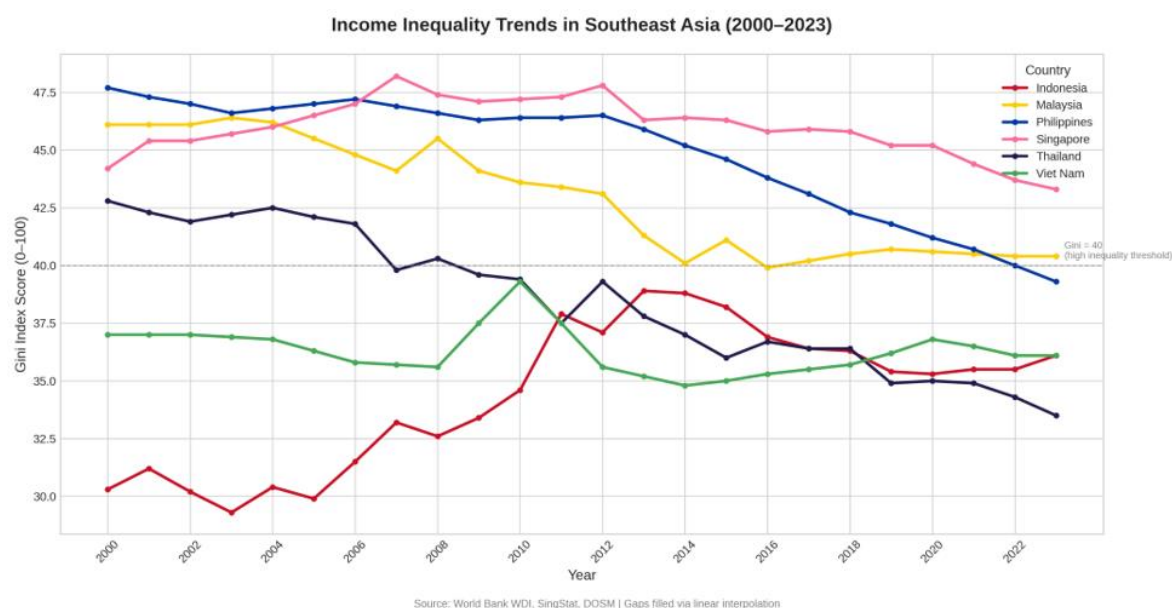


Figure 3. Income inequality trends in selected Southeast Asian countries, 2000–2023 (Gini index)

Source: World Bank.

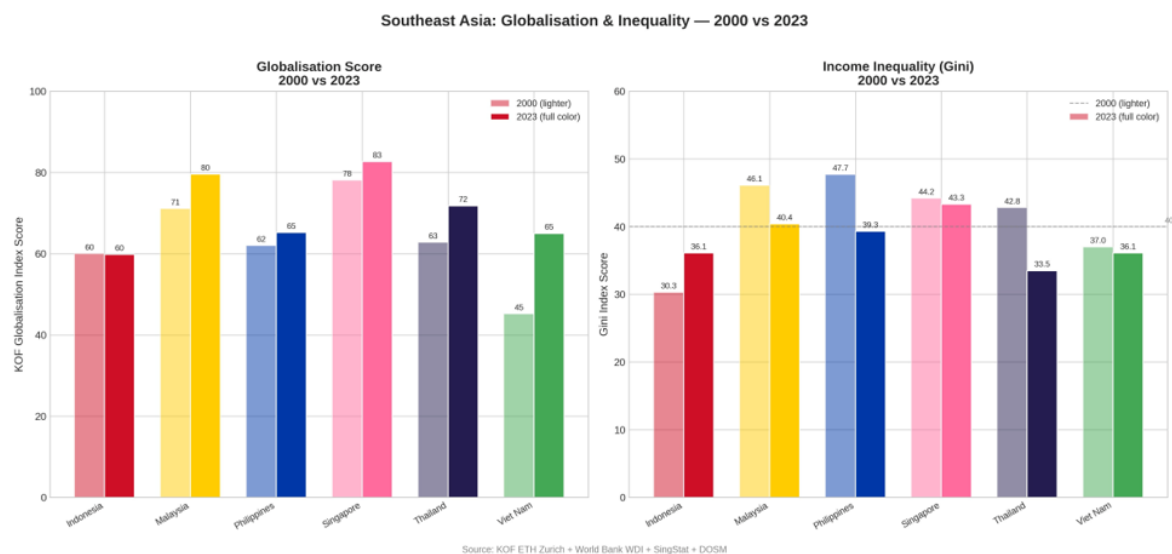


Figure 4. Comparison of globalisation scores and income inequality in Southeast Asia, 2000 and 2023.

Official statistics on income inequality in **Southeast Asia** present a mixed and often unclear picture. **Gini coefficients** across the region between **2000** and **2023** show that inequality has remained relatively high in several countries, declined modestly in others, and in some cases risen before partially falling again (see Figure 3). When the same data are compared at the beginning and end of the period, the overall impression is one of persistence rather than clear resolution (see Figure 4). In mainstream development discussion these figures are sometimes read through the lens of the **Kuznets Curve**, as temporary costs of growth that will eventually decline. From an anthropological

perspective, however, the numbers are far less important than the social relations and lived experiences they leave out of view.

Inequality under neoliberal globalisation is not simply a gap between income groups. It is organised through the everyday organisation of labour, the distribution of risk, and the unequal burden of social reproduction. On oil palm plantations, in export factories and in the expanding services sector, large numbers of people work under conditions of tight discipline and limited security while a smaller group of managers, landowners, and capital owners capture disproportionate returns. **Tammisto's (2019)** ethnography makes this relation concrete. Workers experience the plantation as a place of controlled and often exhausting labour, yet many continue to orient their lives toward the village. The cash they earn is frequently sent back to their villages, helping to cover a substantial share of the costs of sustaining life, food, care, housing, and the maintenance of social ties while the plantation benefits from a labour force whose full reproduction is not paid for in the wage. The result is a structural subsidy running from the non-market sphere to the capitalist one.

Gender deepens these inequalities. The “**girl effect**” discourse and related empowerment programmes present young women's entry into the labour market as a straightforward path to progress and autonomy (**Hickel 2014**). In practice, many women find themselves in precarious, low-paid, or highly controlled forms of work while still carrying most of the unpaid care and household labour. The language of empowerment can therefore mask or hide a double burden: women are expected to bootstrap themselves and their families out of poverty while the wider structures that produce that poverty debt relations, land concentration and flexible labour regimes remain largely unchallenged. What appears in policy documents as inclusion is often experienced as intensified responsibility under conditions of insecurity.

People's own categories reveal the cultural dimensions of these arrangements. When Mengen workers say that “**life in the village is free**”, they are not making romantic claims about the absence of hardship. They are contrasting two different moral economies: one in which work is organised according to household and community rhythms, and another in which time, movement, and effort are commended by others. Similar distinctions appear across Southeast Asia, where people move between rural homes, industrial zones, and cities. Freedom, security, and a good life are judged not only by the presence of cash but by the quality of social relations, the ability to meet kinship obligations, and the degree of control people retain over their own labour and time.

Frank's (1966) earlier insights remain relevant here. The inequalities visible today are not simply the temporary by-product of modernisation. They are continuously produced through relations that link local labour and land to wider circuits of accumulation. Development discourse and the **anti-politics machine** help to hide this production. By treating inequality as a technical problem of insufficient growth or inadequate skills, attention is diverted from the political questions of who

controls resources, who sets the terms of labour, and who absorbs the social costs when those terms change (**Escobar 1995; Ferguson 1994**).

In short, the persistence of inequality in official figures is less significant than the ways inequality is organised and experienced in daily life. Rising globalisation scores and periods of economic growth have not removed the unequal relations between capital and labour, between market and non-market spheres, or between those who command and those who must adapt. An anthropological reading insists that these relations, rather than the aggregate numbers, must stand at the centre of any serious judgement about well-being.

5. Critical Anthropological Synthesis

The evidence examined in this essay does not support the claim that globalisation has straightforwardly improved the well-being of the majority of people in Southeast Asia. Official indicators record rising globalisation scores and periods of economic growth, yet these measures operate within the developmentalist and anti-political frameworks described by **Escobar (1995)** and **Ferguson (1994)**. They record the expansion of markets while saying very little about the reorganisation of social relations, the distribution of risk, and the cultural evaluations people make of their own lives.

Neoliberal globalisation, as analysed by **Harvey (2005)**, has created new opportunities for cash income and mobility for some groups. At the same time, it has involved the creative destruction of earlier securities and the deepening of unequal relations between those who command capital and those who sell their labour. Ethnographic insights, particularly from plantation and rural industrial settings, show that many people continue to orient their lives toward non-market forms of social reproduction even while working within the market. The village or the household often covers the costs of labour that the wage does not fully pay for (**Tammisto 2019**). What is presented in policy language as empowerment or inclusion can therefore be experienced as greater responsibility under more insecure conditions, especially for women (**Hickel 2014**).

Frank's (1966) earlier argument remains useful here: the inequalities visible today are not temporary growing pains on the way to maturity, as the **Kuznets** hypothesis suggests. They are actively produced through ongoing relations that link local labour and the land to wider circuits of accumulation. Development discourse helps to naturalise these relations by presenting them as technical problems of insufficient growth or inadequate skills rather than as questions of power.

An anthropological assessment therefore reaches a more cautious conclusion. Globalisation has changed the conditions of life across Southeast Asia in important ways. It has opened new possibilities for some and new forms of insecurity for many others. Well-being, however, cannot be judged from

aggregate figures alone. It has to be understood through the quality of social relations, the degree of control people keep over their labour and time, and the ability to sustain lives that make sense according to local values. On these terms, the dominant claim that globalisation has improved majority well-being appears partial at best, and for large numbers of people, difficult to sustain.

6. conclusion

This essay has examined the claim that globalisation has improved the well-being of the majority of people in the Global South, with particular attention to Southeast Asia. When approached through an anthropological lens, the claim is difficult to sustain in any simple way. While processes of market integration have generated new sources of cash income and selective opportunities for certain groups, they have reorganised social relations in ways that increase inequality, shift the burdens of social reproduction, and weaken earlier forms of security.

The official narrative of progress depends heavily on aggregate indicators and on a developmentalist discourse that treats the expansion of markets as naturally beneficial. Anthropological analysis, by contrast, begins from lived experience: the everyday organisation of labour, the moral differences people draw between places and forms of work, the gendered distribution of responsibility, and the persistent entanglement of market and non-market spheres. From this perspective, well-being cannot be reduced to rising globalisation scores or periods of economic growth. It is constituted through the quality of social relations, the degree of autonomy people retain over their time and labour, and the capacity to sustain lives that remain meaningful according to local values.

The evidence reviewed here suggests that globalisation has produced a more complex and unequal landscape of experience than the dominant claim allows. For many people in Southeast Asia, the gains of market integration remain partial, ambiguous, and costly. An anthropological perspective does not deny that material conditions have changed, it insists that those changes must be evaluated through the social relations and cultural meanings in which they are embedded. Only on these terms can the question of well-being be adequately addressed.

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